

House OKs bill to end longest shutdown of the U.S. government

President is set to sign package. Closure hit federal workers and low-income people.

By ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — The longest government shutdown in U.S. history was poised to come to an end Wednesday night as the House passed a spending package that President Trump was ready to sign into law as soon as it reached his desk.

The shutdown deal — approved by the House in a narrow 222-209 vote — now heads to Trump, who was scheduled to hold a signing ceremony at the White House at 9:45 p.m. EST.

“President Trump looks forward to finally ending this devastating Democrat shutdown with his signature, and we hope that signing will take place later tonight,” White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt said at a news briefing earlier in the day.

The president’s signature will mark the end of a government shutdown that for 43 days left thousands of federal workers without pay, millions of low-income Americans uncertain on whether they would receive

food assistance, and travelers facing delays at airports.

The vote, which began Wednesday evening, also capped a frenetic day on Capitol Hill in which lawmakers publicly released a trove of records from Jeffrey Epstein’s estate and welcomed the newest member of Congress, a Democrat from Arizona who was key in forcing a vote to demand the Justice Department release all the Epstein files.

The spending package, when signed by the president, will fund the government through Jan. 30 and reinstate federal workers who were laid off during the shutdown. It will also guarantee back pay for federal employees who were furloughed or worked without pay during the budget impasse.

The package does not include an extension to Affordable Care Act healthcare tax credits that are set to expire at the end of the year — a core demand Democrats tried to negotiate during the more than six weeks the government was shut down.

“This fight is not over, we are just getting started,” House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries said in his closing argument on the House floor. “We will fight until we win this battle for the American people.”

[See House, A6]



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

READY TO TAKE FLIGHT

The Lucas Museum of Narrative Art, which will feature 35 galleries and two theaters in Exposition Park, plans to launch in 2026. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

EPSTEIN EMAIL TROVE NAMES TRUMP

He ‘knew about the girls,’ the accused sex trafficker wrote about the president in 2019.

By JENNY JARVIE, MICHAEL WILNER AND KEVIN RECTOR

Donald Trump “spent hours at my house” and “knew about the girls,” Jeffrey Epstein, the disgraced financier accused of orchestrating sex trafficking of young women and underage girls, wrote in private emails released Wednesday by House Democrats.

The release of a small batch of Epstein’s communications sent shock waves through Washington, prompting a panicked defense of the president from White House aides who accused Democrats of colluding with the media to smear him. It also triggered Republican lawmakers to release an additional 20,000 documents from Epstein’s private estate, a move Democrats said was designed to distract from the implication of Trump.

But several of the documents shared by the Republicans added fuel to the fire, highlighting Epstein’s interest in Trump in the years after Trump claimed their friendship had come to an end, and suggesting the convicted sex offender had information on the president he was keeping secret.

By Wednesday afternoon, House Democrats — and a few Republicans — secured enough signatures for a petition that would force a chamber vote on the release of Justice Department files related to the Epstein investigation.

The drama began Wednesday morning, when Democrats released three of Epstein’s old email exchanges.

“Of course he knew about the girls,” Epstein said of Trump in an email to author

[See Epstein, A5]

Facing huge deficit, USC leader ‘optimistic’

By DANIEL MILLER

The University of Southern California is in the throes of its most aggressive cost-cutting drive in memory — a grinding period of financial austerity that has shaken the university’s moneyed reputation and raised doubts among faculty and staff about the school’s ability to sustain itself as a top-tier institution.

Aiming to eliminate a budget deficit that ballooned to more than \$200 million, the private school has cut nearly 1,000 positions, or almost 4% of its workforce.

Faculty and staff said that the layoffs have been especially stressful because they have been ongoing for months, although the university said last week that they are nearly complete — and that as many as 200 of those who lost their jobs could find new positions at the school.

Other cost-saving measures have included restrictions on discretionary spending, such as travel for conferences.

“There’s a sense of just fear and anxiety among all staff. Even those who are safe don’t know if this is just

[See USC, A7]

L.A. sets historic cap on rent hikes

By NOAH GOLDBERG

Los Angeles strengthened its rent stabilization law for the first time in 40 years Wednesday, setting a 4% ceiling on annual rent increases for a massive portion of the city’s housing stock.

The historic vote by the L.A. City Council will help set rents for decades to come for tenants who live in units built before 1978 — nearly half of the city’s residents.

Two council members voted against the new rules, arguing that they would tip the scale against landlords and could chill development. The measure’s backers said the changes were necessary for tenants struggling to make rent every month.

“The city has not done enough to protect renters,” said Councilmember Nithya Raman, who wrote the proposal. “What we have right now is an opportunity to make L.A. more affordable, because when people can afford to stay in Los Angeles, this entire city thrives.”

The vote came as L.A. and many parts of the country are struggling with a housing affordability crisis, and after democratic socialist Zohran Mamdani won the New York City mayor’s election on a pledge to “freeze the rent.”

Most Angelenos are renters, and more than half are rent-burdened, meaning they spend more than 30% of their income on rent, according to the city’s Housing Department. One in 10 Angelenos pays 90% of their in-

[See Rents, A11]

Climate gives Newsom a world stage

By MELODY GUTIERREZ

BELÉM, Brazil — The expansive halls of the Amazon’s newly built climate summit hub echoed with the hum of air conditioners and the footsteps of delegates from around the world — scientists, diplomats, Indigenous leaders and energy executives, all converging for two frenetic weeks of negotiations.

Then Gov. Gavin Newsom rounded the corner, flanked by staff and security. They moved in tandem through the corridors on Tuesday as media swarmed and cellphone cameras rose into the air.

“Herol!” one woman shouted. “Stay safe — we need you,” another attendee said. Others didn’t hide their confusion at who the man with slicked-back graying hair causing such a commotion was.

“I’m here because I don’t want the United States of America to be a footnote at this conference,” Newsom said when he reached a packed news conference on

The potential presidential contender grabs global spotlight as he positions California as a stand-in for U.S. at Brazil summit



ALESSANDRO FALCO

GOV. GAVIN NEWSOM called out President Trump at the COP30 climate summit in Belém, Brazil.

Easy prey for ID thieves: Foreign scholars

L.A. ring targets those who moved on after U.S. stints, expert says

By CLARA HARTER

Using apartments in the San Fernando Valley and Glendale area, a shadowy group of identity thieves has been quietly exploiting a new kind of victim — foreign scholars who left the U.S. years ago but whose Social Security numbers still linger in American databases, according to a cybercrime expert.

Criminals are resurrecting these dormant identities and submitting hundreds of applications for bank accounts and credit cards, says David

Maimon, head of fraud insights at SentiLink and a criminology professor at Georgia State University. The Southern California-based fraudsters can then max out lines of credit while unknowing victims live halfway across the world, he says.

Sgt. Frank Diana, with the L.A. County Sheriff’s Department Fraud and Cyber Crimes Bureau, said organized crime rings in the county are highly skilled at stealing identities, concealing their IP addresses and laundering their loot to make it hard to detect.

Local identity crime rings “are do-

ing it to make millions of dollars, live in nice houses, all at the expense of taxpayers,” Diana said. “It’s not their money, but they’re living like kings.”

Maimon and his colleague Karl Lubenow said they uncovered this tactic of stealing foreign scholars’ IDs through their work at SentiLink, a company that works with financial institutions to verify identities and detect fraud.

At first they were asked to examine applications on which foreign movie stars and athletes were probably being impersonated.

[See ID theft, A7]

Ex-political aides accused in probe
Ex-advisors to Newsom and Becerra schemed to fund luxuries, the feds allege. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

2028 Olympics schedule released
Largest Games ever feature the women’s 100-meter dash final on Day One. **SPORTS, B10**

Holiday shoppers plan to cut back
Angelenos will spend 14% less this year, a Deloitte retail survey found. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather
Becoming cloudy. L.A. Basin: 73/60. **B6**

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